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The relationships between incivility, team climate for incivility and job-related employee well-being: a multilevel analysis

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ABSTRACT

Adopting a multilevel approach, this study extends the current understanding of workplace incivility by examining the cross-level associations between team climate for incivility, team size and team norms with regard to competitiveness on employees' well-being associated with incivility at work. Using a sample of 637 employees nested in 50 work teams, the results revealed a direct negative effect of uncivil team climates on employee job-related affective well-being, over and above employees' personal experience of uncivil behaviour. As hypothesized, competitive norms significantly moderated the negative effect of experienced incivility on affective well-being, suggesting that competitive team environments may buffer the negative consequences of workplace incivility through a team sensemaking process. Utilizing Social Comparison Theory (comparing how they are treated) and climate strength literature, this study also found team size to be a significant moderator of the incivility–well-being relationship, with members of smaller work teams experiencing more detrimental effects of uncivil acts. Together, these findings suggest that the magnitude of the negative effect of uncivil behaviour is dependent on the composition and incivility climate of work teams. The results of this study have important implications for designing individual- and team-level interventions aimed at addressing uncivil behaviour and climates in the workplace.

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Introduction

Rude and disrespectful behaviour in the workplace has received considerable research attention, with studies indicating that incivility is perhaps the most prevalent form of workplace deviance (Griffin, Bell, & Marusz, 2007; Lim, Cortina, & Magley, 2008). Referring to behaviour that violates workplace norms for mutual respect, examples of incivility include interrupting or ignoring others, using sarcasm, and withholding information (Martin & Hine, 2005). Incivility appears to be a common experience in today's workplace, with a large study of 179 organizations across Australia and New Zealand (Griffin et al., 2007) finding that 85% of employees reported experiencing some form of incivility within the past year. Furthermore, despite its seemingly mild nature, workplace incivility has been shown to have measurable effects on individual and organizational outcomes (Lim et al., 2008; Sakurai & Jex, 2012). For example, targets of uncivil behaviour are

more likely to be dissatisfied with their jobs (Lim et al., 2008), experience psychological distress (Cortina, Magley, Williams, & Langhout, 2001) and engage in counterproductive work behaviours (Penney & Spector, 2005). It is not surprising then that there has been increasing interest amongst academics and practitioners in this milder form of interpersonal deviance.

Despite the growth in research, few have examined the construct beyond the individual level of analysis. This lack of attention to group processes is surprising given the recognized importance of contextual factors and team climate on individual and organizational outcomes (Lindell & Brandt, 2000). Exceptions include Griffin (2010) and Lim et al. (2008); although both these studies aggregated team members' actual experiences of uncivil behaviour, they could not really capture any emergent group-level processes. However, more recently, Paulin and Griffin (2015) operationalized group incivility as a facet-specific climate construct, and in so doing measured the collective or shared perceptions about the team environment in relation to expectations for and valuing of civil interpersonal treatment. They showed how a team's climate for incivility explained incremental variance in team members' job satisfaction and intention to leave beyond their own personal experience of incivility.

We now extend that study by positioning incivility within a multilevel climate framework to provide a more holistic model and a better understanding of how team climate, norms and structure can affect individuals' emotional well-being beyond the effect of their individual experiences. Specifically, this current study adopts the components of Wrzesniewski, Dutton, and Debebe's (2003) interpersonal model of sensemaking and integrates this with multilevel theory and analysis to examine how team climate (incivility), norms (competition) and structure (team size) interact with employees' experience of incivility to affect their job-related affective well-being.

Well-being is an important and costly issue for organizations, with research identifying job-related affective well-being as a significant indicator of mental health, absenteeism and even turnover (Mikikangas, Feldt, & Kinnunen, 2007; Pearson & Porath, 2009). Importantly, incivility has demonstrated predictive relationships with employee well-being and mental health (Lim et al., 2008; Pearson & Porath, 2009). Therefore, the outcome of the current study is job-related affective well-being, which refers to whether an employee is feeling emotionally well or unwell in a work-related context (Mikikangas et al., 2007), and includes emotions such as anxiety, comfort, depression and enthusiasm.

Employee sensemaking: the role of the team context

Based on the tenets of the sensemaking perspective (Roberson & Stevens, 2006; Weick, 1995), the major aim of this paper is to explore team-level moderators of the experienced incivility–well-being relationship. Sensemaking refers to an attentional process whereby employees interpret their environment and subsequently come to assign subjective meanings of events and behaviour (Roberson & Stevens, 2006; Weick, 1995). According to Wrzesniewski et al.'s (2003) interpersonal model of sensemaking, interactions between co-workers create cues that activate an interpretation process. First, employees notice an action or behaviour of another person within their team, known as an interpersonal cue. Employees then interpret whether the behaviour is positive, negative or neutral, before making sense of why someone acted the way that they did (Wrzesniewski et al.,

2003). When related to a negative behaviour, an employee's assessment of the reason for the behaviour will either increase or decrease the negative effect of their original assessment of the behaviour.

According to Weick (1995), the sensemaking process is particularly relevant for interpreting unexpected or ambiguous events in the workplace. Given the ambiguous nature of workplace incivility, sensemaking is therefore likely to play an important role in determining the extent to which uncivil behaviour negatively affects employee well-being. For more serious forms of interpersonal mistreatment, such as violence and harassment, the interpersonal cues are explicit, and therefore likely to have a stronger direct effect on well-being and strain (Spector, Coulter, Stockwell, & Matz, 2007). However, for uncivil behaviour, the interpersonal cues are much less overt and therefore employees are more likely to look to their co-workers and their team context to draw meaning from these cues (Wrzesniewski et al., 2003).

In their studies of sensemaking, both Weick (1995) and Wrzesniewski et al. (2003) identified work teams as one of the most powerful contextual factors that influence the way employees make sense of behaviour in the workplace. Specifically, the team context influences the likelihood that an interpersonal cue will be noticed in the first place, whether or not the behaviour is assessed as negative, and the motive assigned to the action. Contextual team factors are therefore likely to play a considerable role in the extent to which employees experience reduced well-being as a result of uncivil behaviour. Wrzesniewski et al. (2003) specified three particular team constructs worthy of further research, namely team structure, team climate and team norms. Recognizing that there are a myriad of team contextual variables that could be examined within each of these categories, this study examines team incivility climate (team climate variable), team norms regarding competitiveness (team norms variable) and team size (team structure variable).

Team-level incivility as a facet-specific climate construct

Before focusing on why team-level incivility will moderate the effect of experienced incivility on affective well-being, we discuss why team climate for incivility is also likely to have a direct influence on individual team members' well-being regardless of the uncivil treatment they are personally subjected to.

When studied at the individual level of analysis, workplace incivility is operationalized as the extent or frequency that an employee experiences uncivil behaviour (Griffin, 2010). Such research has included investigation of the characteristics of instigators and targets of incivility (Milam, Spitzmueller, & Penney, 2009), the outcomes of individuals' experiences of incivility (Cortina et al., 2001; Martin & Hine, 2005), and the role of individual appraisal and perception (Cortina & Magley, 2009). Within the traditional stressor-strain framework, employees' experience of incivility is typically classified as a type of workplace stressor (Fox, Spector, & Miles, 2001; Jex, 1998). Research on workplace incivility and the interpersonal deviance literature more broadly has provided support for a negative relationship between incivility (stressor) and affective well-being (strain). For example, Cortina et al. (2001) found that employees' experiences of uncivil behaviour were associated with greater psychological distress.

Extending this individual experience view of incivility, Lim et al. (2008) and Griffin (2010) investigated group and organizational-level incivility, respectively. Lim et al. (2008) defined the group-level construct as a measure of vicarious exposure of the

individual to incivility. Griffin (2010) emphasized the shared nature of the group-level variable, defining the construct as the environment of incivility that is experienced within a group or organization. Underlying these definitions is the premise that workplace incivility at the individual level is a separate and distinct construct from incivility at the group level, whereby group-level incivility can account for unique variance in employee outcomes, over and above that of individual-level incivility. In other words, Griffin (2010) and Lim et al. (2008) examined incivility as a type of job stressor that can be experienced both directly by an employee (at the individual-level) as well as one that can manifest at the group level and is the aggregate or collective team experience of incivility. Lim et al. (2008), who looked at the adverse consequences of uncivil behaviour on targets' psychological and physical well-being, found a significant relationship between workplace incivility, well-being and mental health.

The current study takes a different approach to conceptualizing the higher order incivility construct by proposing that it operates as a facet-specific climate construct. Team climate is central to employees' work experiences and has been shown to be an important factor affecting employee behaviour and outcomes (Ehrhart, Schneider, & Macey, 2014). Incivility climate is defined as a distinct team cognition about the practices, procedures and norms that are rewarded or supported concerning workplace incivility (Paulin & Griffin, 2015). A climate for incivility emerges when team practices, procedures and norms encourage, or fail to prevent, uncivil behaviour occurring within the team. As required when validating a new climate construct (e.g. Morrison, Wheeler-Smith, & Kamdar, 2011; Takeuchi, Chen, & Lepak, 2007), Paulin and Griffin (2015) were able to show that team climate for incivility is empirically distinct from individuals' personal experiences of incivility and can be used to explain variance in outcomes (e.g. job satisfaction and intention to leave) beyond that accounted for by individual experiences even when these are aggregated to a higher level.

According to Paulin and Griffin (2015), when uncivil behaviour permeates the team climate, members are likely to develop negative feelings towards both the team and concern for themselves. Over time, this will have a detrimental effect beyond personal experience on the overall health and well-being as team members observe that rude behaviour go uncorrected, develop expectations that this is how they will likely be treated in the future, and interpret this context as indicating that team members are not valued. For example, Kessler, Spector, Chang, and Parr (2008) and Spector et al. (2007) found that team climates of violence had a detrimental effect on employees' physical and psychological well-being, beyond that of individuals' direct experience of violence and aggression. According to Kessler et al. (2008), this may be due to the fact that a high violence climate signals to employees that the organization is not concerned with protecting their safety, which in turn leads to increased feelings of anxiety and fear. It is therefore hypothesized that incivility climate will have a direct negative impact on employee well-being:

Hypothesis 1: A team climate for incivility will be negatively related to job-related affective well-being, over and above the effect of individually experienced incivility.

We now turn to the expected moderating role of team climate for incivility. Studies investigating team climate as a moderating variable of lower order relationships are relatively rare, with Ehrhart et al. (2014) emphasizing the urgent need for such multilevel research.

Referring to the process by which one's standing relevant to others influences attitudes and behaviours (Buunk & Gibbons, 2007), social comparisons are a central part of the way employees evaluate their work environment (Greenberg, Ashton-James, & Ashkanasy, 2007). According to social comparison theory (Festinger, 1954), team climate can amplify the behavioural and affective reactions of employees to environmental stimuli by providing signals for how to interpret events (Mussweiler, 2003). In other words, one way employees' may make sense of their uncivil experiences is to assess the practices, policies and norms that exist within their immediate work environment and compare how they and others are treated (Folger & Cropanzano, 1998), which in turn will affect their emotional response to the event (Wulumbwa, Hartnell, & Oke, 2010).

An example of how employees use social comparison to make sense of personally experienced interpersonal mistreatment is the so-called "singled out hypothesis" proposed by Duffy, Ganster, Shaw, Johnson, and Pagon (2006) and supported by Griffin (2010). The singled-out effect occurs when employees who are mistreated by their co-workers have a *more* negative response if they work in environments where such treatment is not condoned and few others are treated this way (Duffy et al., 2006). For example, Griffin (2010) found that organizational-level incivility moderated the relationship between individual-level incivility and intention to leave, which was stronger when the aggregated incidence of incivility was low. When an employee's negative experience of incivility is similar to the majority of their co-workers, the impact of that incivility may not be as severe because the employee can interpret the situation as being caused by something in the work environment that is common to others in the same environment. Conversely, when an employee is treated in an uncivil manner in a work context where few others are targeted with incivility, or where incivility is not a characteristic of the team climate, they are more likely to make personal attributions about the cause. When people blame themselves for a negative event, such as being treated in an uncivil manner, the impact of the event is more detrimental (Bowling & Beehr, 2006). Therefore, it is hypothesized that:

Hypothesis 2: A team climate for incivility will moderate the relationship between personally experienced incivility and job-related affective well-being, such that the negative relationship will be stronger when team incivility climate is low.

We note that Hypothesis 2 might initially seem counter-intuitive in light of Hypothesis 1, so emphasize that the direct effect of team climate for incivility (H1) explains between-groups variance (i.e. intercept variation) in individual well-being, whereas the moderating effect (H2) means that team climate for incivility is expected to independently alter an existing individual-level or within-group relationship (i.e. slope variation). Both Duffy et al. (2006) and Griffin (2010) demonstrated this direct negative effect of a group variable on an individual outcome and at the same time the moderating effect that weakened the relationship between an individual-level predictor and the outcome.

Competitive team norms

Apart from social comparisons of their experience, another way employees might interpret or make sense of uncivil behaviour (and thus, the extent to which they experience a decline in well-being) is to reframe the experience as some kind of necessary or acceptable way of behaving, given the work conditions. Competitive team norms offer one such lens through

which employees may reframe their experiences of incivility. For example, in teams with highly competitive norms, members may be able to reframe workplace incivility by interpreting it as “what you have to do” to succeed, or “just how people respond” to the organizational pressures to perform.

Competitive norms refer to the degree to which employees perceive organizational rewards to be contingent on comparisons of their performance against that of their peers (Brown, Cron, & Slocum, 1998). Competition *within* teams is generally seen to be unhealthy (Kohn, 1992) and when experienced can foster negative interpersonal behaviours and poor individual outcomes. For example, within-team competition norms are related to the quality of friendships, interpersonal relationships, sabotage behaviour and denigration of others (Charness, Masclet, & Villeval, 2014; Ryckman, Hammer, Kaczor, & Gold, 1996). When rewards for team members are contingent on their performance compared with others within the team, the kind of competitive norms that can develop include taking credit for other people’s work, undermining co-workers’ contributions, and failing to help others (Duffy et al., 2006).

Despite the often negative impact of competition within teams, including the impact it has on the way employees treat one another, competition is a relatively under-researched team factor. This is quite surprising given that competitive behaviour is of high salience in many work contexts (Heidemeier & Bittner, 2012), possibly none more so than within work teams with high interdependence. Indeed, qualitative information collected from focus groups in one of the organizations participating in the current study indicated within-team competition to be key factor in promoting uncivil behaviour.

Hypothesis 3: Higher team norms for inter-team competition will have a negative cross-level effect on job-related affective well-being.

While increasing the actual amount of uncivil behaviour, on the one hand, competitive norms may also change the interpretation of incivility. As argued by Wrzesniewski et al., (2003), norms can impact the sensemaking process. With regard to making sense of incidences of uncivil treatment, the members of teams with highly competitive norms are likely to develop a shared understanding that uncivil behaviour is “part and parcel” of working within a team, which in turn, legitimizes the experience of uncivil behaviour and reduces the overall impact on employee well-being (Ashmos & Nathan, 2002). In teams with less competitive norms, team members will be unlikely to engage in this reframing to explain uncivil behaviour, because there is no “reason” for the behaviour within the team context. Due to the greater perceived violation of team norms and shared mental models, the negative consequences of workplace incivility on employee well-being with non-competitive team norms are likely to be stronger. Therefore, the following hypothesis is proposed:

Hypothesis 4: Competitive within-team norms will moderate the relationship between experienced incivility and job-related affective well-being, such that the negative relationship will be stronger when competitive team norms are low.

Team structure

In addition to incivility team climate and norms, we adopt the suggestion by Wrzesniewski et al. (2003) to study team structure variables as a sensemaking vehicle for

moderating the impact of workplace events (such as experienced incivility) on outcomes (such as job-related well-being). Team size is a structural factor known to have roles in determining both individual outcomes and the internal functioning of teams (Cremer & Leonardelli, 2003; Wheelan, 2009). For example, size influences team cohesion, quality of team experiences, social comparisons and cooperation, with such factors decreasing as teams become bigger (Cremer & Leonardelli, 2003; Pruitt, 1998; Wheelan, 2009). Likewise, Aube, Rousseau, and Tremblay (2011) found that members of larger teams were significantly more likely to engage in social loafing, interpersonal aggression, and misuse of resources. Indeed, in that study, team size accounted for approximately 20% of the variance in interpersonal aggression. In explaining such results, Cremer and Leonardelli (2003) suggest that it is the greater presence of social constraints in smaller teams that promotes collective interest. In larger teams, social constraints are absent, or present to a lesser degree, with employees' feeling less identifiable, less accountable, and less personally responsible for their teams' overall welfare. In turn, cooperation is reduced as employees in larger teams become more driven by personal self-interest than collective benefits.

Hypothesis 5: Team size will have a negative effect on an individual's job-related affective well-being.

As described above, social comparison theory (Festinger, 1954) also provides support for a moderating effect of team size, suggesting that the negative consequences of experienced incivility would be stronger within smaller work teams. In small teams, social comparisons may be more easily generated by the target of interpersonal mistreatment and result in stronger perceptions of injustice. Targets working within smaller teams may also feel that their experiences are more on display and that their vulnerability as a victim is more obvious to the team, resulting in a stronger negative reaction. Furthermore, when there are fewer people in a team, episodes of interpersonal mistreatment may result in employees feeling singled-out, which, in turn, results in a stronger decline in their overall well-being. In large teams, social comparisons may be less easily generated by targets because of the high numbers of possible comparisons. Specific incidents of uncivil behaviour may be less obvious within the team, that is, unlikely to be observed by the majority of the team members, and because targets feel less on display, the overall negative impact on their well-being may be weakened.

The proposed buffering effect of team size on the relationship between personally experienced incivility and well-being due to the way incivility is interpreted might also occur due to the likely differences in social support between small and large teams. When uncivil behaviour occurs in small teams, there may be fewer colleagues that the employee can turn to for support and guidance. In large teams, the target is likely to have more team members who are removed from the specific incident to turn to for support, in turn reducing negative emotions and buffering the negative outcomes of experiencing uncivil behaviour. Indeed, research has shown that employees who experience workplace incivility report better outcomes when they felt organizationally and emotionally supported (Sakurai & Jex, 2012). Applying the social comparison and social support literature, the following hypothesis is proposed:

Hypothesis 6: Team size will moderate the relationship between experienced incivility and job-related affective well-being, such that the negative relationship will be stronger when the team size is smaller.

Method

Participants

The sample for this study consisted of 637 employees nested in 50 work teams across 5 Australian organizations, which included not-for-profit, public and private sector companies across 5 industries, including financial services, health, marketing, professional services and telecommunications. Respondents worked in roles requiring a high degree of interdependence and interpersonal interaction, which is important given the study's focus on employees' interpersonal behaviour. Teams selected to participate in the study were well-established teams who work together towards common goals under co-located managers or team leaders. The size of these teams ranged from 6 to 44 members, with a mean of 24 ($SD = 11.3$). The average team member response rate was 46%, with 4–23 responding from each team ($M = 11$; $SD = 5.1$).

Just over half the individual participants (55%) were female and their ages ranged from 18 to 73 years ($M = 34$; $SD = 9.44$). Mean job tenure was 5.7 years ($SD = 6.5$). In terms of role within the teams, 57% of respondents were team members, 32% were middle managers and 11% were senior managers. Of the respondents, 25% had a school or high school certificate, 43% had a bachelor degree or technical college certificate and 32% had a postgraduate degree.

Measures

The survey was administered online, although a small percentage of respondents completed a hardcopy version. Participation was voluntary and anonymous so that teams did not know which of their members had responded.

Outcome measure

Job-related affective well-being was assessed using Warr's scale (Mikikangas et al., 2007). Respondents were required to describe how frequently their job had made them feel each of 16 emotions in the past month using a 7-point scale (from 1 = "never, 0% of the time" to 7 = "always, 100% of the time"). Examples of emotions included "enthusiastic", "nervous" and "calm". The eight negative emotions were reverse scored so that higher scores indicated a high level of well-being ($\alpha = .88$).

Individual-level measure

Workplace incivility was measured with Cortina et al.'s (2001) 11-item Workplace Incivility Scale (WIS). Respondents were required to rate on a 5-point scale (from 1 = "never" to 5 = "very often") statements describing how often they had experienced uncivil behaviours within their team (i.e. supervisor and co-workers) within the past six months. Items included "ignored you or failed to speak to you"; "made jokes at your expense"; and "made demeaning or derogatory remarks about you". The Cronbach alpha was .91.

Group-level measures

Team size was provided for each of the teams by the team supervisor. Team incivility climate was measured using the eight-item Team Incivility Climate Scale (TICS; Paulin & Griffin, 2015). The eight items are aligned with the definition of team incivility climate, such that they measure employees' shared perceptions of expectations, practices and procedures regarding uncivil team behaviours, using the collective team entity as the reference point. Respondents were required to rate the items on a 5-point scale, ranging from 1 = "strongly disagree" to 5 = "strongly agree". Items included "people within my team shame and humiliate each other" and "there are clear policies and procedures that prohibit uncivil behaviour in this team (r)". A referent shift consensus model (Chan, 1998) was utilized because the climate literature broadly agrees that this best captures and measures the shared, interdependent nature of climate constructs (Chen, Mathieu, & Bliese, 2003). Aggregation of the individual ratings to form a measure of incivility climate was justified by a mean $r_{wg(j)}$ of .91 ($SD = .02$), and an intraclass class correlation (ICC) value of .06, with significant between-group variance ($Wald\ Z = 2.34, p < .05$). However, as in most studies of interpersonal mistreatment, the measure of team climate for incivility was positively skewed ($M = 1.88$). Therefore, guided by Smith-Crowe, Burke, Cohen, and Doveh (2014), we also calculated the $r_{wg(j)}$ score assuming a skewed distribution of responses. The resulting $r_{wg(j)}$ was significantly different from 0 at .05, with a $r_{wg(j)}$ of .82 ($SD = .05$). The data demonstrated good reliability, with a Cronbach alpha of .86.

Competitive team norms was measured using four items from Brown et al.'s (1998) scale, which were modified to be less specific to sales roles. Example items were "everybody is concerned with being the top performer", and "the amount of recognition you get in this team depends on how you perform compared to others". Responses were made on a 5-point Likert scale from 1 = "strongly disagree" to 5 = "strongly agree". The four items at the individual level yielded a Cronbach alpha of .74. Aggregation of the individual ratings to form a measure of competitive team norms was justified by a mean $r_{wg(j)}$ score of .92 ($SD = .03$) with all team $r_{wg(j)}$ scores above the 0.70 cut-off criteria, and an ICC value of .19, with significant between-group variance ($Wald\ Z = 3.63, p < .001$).

Analysis

The data for this study contained a hierarchical structure in which respondents were embedded within work teams. Multilevel modelling techniques have been developed to analyse such nested data structures (Hofman, Griffin, & Gavin, 2000) and allow for the examination of cross-level effects (Bliese & Jex, 2002). To meet the conditions for multi-level analysis, the assumptions of justifiable aggregation and significant between-group variance were tested. First, $r_{wg(j)}$ scores using a uniform null distribution were used to assess the within-group agreement (James, Damaree, & Wolf, 1984; Klien & Kozlowski, 2000). As previously described, aggregation of individual-level measures of incivility climate and competitive norms to the team level was justified, with $r_{wg(j)}$ scores of above .90 for both measures. Recognizing the ongoing debate regarding the use of $r_{wg(j)}$ scores, we ran the analysis both including and removing the small number of teams with low $r_{wg(j)}$ scores (Smith-Crowe et al., 2014). Given the similarity of results, we

presented the results with all 50 teams included in the analysis. Significant between-group variance further justified aggregation of incivility climate and competitive norms to the group level.

An unconditional means model was conducted to assess if there was meaningful individual and group variation in well-being between work teams. The ICC for well-being was .045, with significant between-groups variance ($\chi^2_{(49)} = 76.88, p < .01$). While not large, this value is typical for those usually found in applied organizational research (Bliese & Jex, 2002). The hypothesized cross-level effects were tested using HLM6 (Raudenbush, Bryk, & Congdon, 2004). In addition to the null model, three random intercept models were fitted sequentially to examine: (1) the effect of experienced incivility on job-related affective well-being; (2) the direct effect of group-level factors on well-being (Hypothesis 1); and (3) the effect of the cross-level moderators (Hypotheses 2–4). Group mean centring of the experienced incivility variable and grand mean centring of Level 2 predictor variables were used for hypothesis testing. Simple slope and regions of significance tests were also conducted for the interaction hypotheses and included in the figure notes (Preacher, Curran, & Bauer, 2006). Finally, we investigated the potential effect of organizational membership by creating five dummy variables and including them in the analysis. However, organizational membership was non-significant and did not change the overall results, so the results have not been reported for ease of interpretation.

Results

Effect of experienced incivility

Table 1 presents the means, standard deviations and correlations of the individual and group-level measures. As shown, experienced incivility was significantly correlated with job-related affective well-being ($r = -.46, p < .01$). The random coefficients model (Table 2) confirmed this relationship within groups, with experienced incivility explaining 24.09% (i.e. $[(.648 - .492) / .492 = .241]$) of the within-group variation in employee well-being.

Table 2 presents the results of three mixed models fitted sequentially. Table 2 also provides pseudo- R^2 values to show the amount of variance explained by each of the models.

Table 1. Descriptive statistics, correlations and internal consistencies.

Variables	<i>M</i>	<i>SD</i>	1	2	3	4	5
Level 1 variables							
(1) Experienced incivility	1.54	.59	(.91)				
(2) Job-related affective well-being	4.87	.83	-.46**	(.88)			
Level 2 variables							
(3) Incivility climate	1.88	.23	.27**	-.21**	(.86)		
(4) Team size	24.41	11.37	.05	-.08	.06	–	
(5) Competitive team norms	2.83	.80	.27**	-.27**	.09*	.21**	(.74)

Note: For individual-level measures, $n = 637$; for team-level measures, $n = 50$. Level 1 variables were aggregated to provide estimates of between-team relationships with level 2 variables. Figures in parentheses are Cronbach alphas.

* $p < .05$; ** $p < .01$.

Table 2. Multilevel regression estimates for the effects of incivility, team size and competitive team norms on job-related affective well-being.

Variable	Null model			Model 1			Model 2			Model 3		
	Est.	SE	T	Est.	SE	T	Est.	SE	T	Est.	SE	T
<i>Level 1 main effects</i>												
Intercept	4.88	0.04	115.47**	4.88	0.04	115.72**	4.88	0.03	152.06**	4.88	0.03	152.31**
Experienced incivility				−0.67	0.07	−9.34**	−0.68	0.07	−9.44**	−0.67	0.06	−10.45**
<i>Level 2 main effects</i>												
Incivility climate								0.10	−6.89**	−0.71	0.10	−6.84**
Team size								0.00	−1.58	−0.00	0.00	−1.13
Competitive team norms								0.08	−2.53*	−0.19	0.09	−2.05*
<i>Cross-level interactions</i>												
Experienced incivility × incivility climate										−0.10	0.18	−0.59
Experienced incivility × team size										0.01	0.01	2.36*
Experienced incivility × competitive team norms										0.34	0.15	2.34*
σ^2_{within}	0.648			0.492			0.490			0.489		
σ^2_{y0}	0.032			0.044			0.014			0.014		
σ^2_{u1}				0.081			0.079			0.049		
df	49			49			46			46		
Pseudo R^2				0.24			0.76			0.38		

Note: Est. = estimate; σ^2 = variance.

* $p < .05$; ** $p < .001$.

Direct effects

The statistical model for the main effect model and thus testing Hypotheses 1, 3 and 5 was:

$$\text{Level 1: } WB_{ij} = \beta_{0j} + \beta_{1j}(EI_{ij}) + r_{ij},$$

$$\text{Level 2: } \beta_{0j} = \gamma_{00} + \gamma_{01}(IC_{ij}) + \gamma_{02}(TS_{ij}) + \gamma_{03}(CN_{ij}) + u_{0j},$$

$$\beta_{1j} = \gamma_{10} + u_{1j},$$

(where WB refers to well-being, β_{0j} refers to the intercept, EI refers to experienced incivility, r_{ij} refers to the error term of the level 1 intercept, γ_{00} refers to the intercept of the level 2 regression, IC refers to incivility climate, TS refers to team size, CN refers to competitive norms and u_{0j} refers to the error term for the level 1 intercept). The results are reported in Table 2 where it can be seen that together the three level 2 variables accounted for 76% of the between-groups variance in the relationship between individually experienced incivility and well-being.

As shown in Table 2, a climate for incivility within work teams had a direct negative effect on job-related affective well-being ($t = -6.89, p < .01$) supporting Hypothesis 1. It accounted for 59% of the variance in team well-being beyond the effect of team size and competitive norms. As predicted (Hypothesis 3), it can be seen from Table 2 that competitive team norms also had a significant direct effect on well-being ($t = -2.53, p < .05$). It accounted for 14% of the between-groups variance in well-being beyond the effect of team size and climate. In contrast, Hypothesis 5 was not supported because team size did not relate to well-being.

Cross-level moderation

The statistical model for the cross-level interactions model and thus testing Hypotheses 2–4 was:

$$\text{Level 1: } WB_{ij} = \beta_{0j} + \beta_{1j}(EI_{ij}) + r_{ij},$$

$$\text{Level 2: } \beta_{0j} = \gamma_{00} + \gamma_{01}(IC_{ij}) + \gamma_{02}(TS_{ij}) + \gamma_{03}(CN_{ij}) + u_{0j},$$

$$\beta_{1j} = \gamma_{10} + \gamma_{11}(IC_j) + \gamma_{12}(TS_j) + \gamma_{13}(CN_j) + u_{1j}.$$

The variation in slopes was significant ($\chi^2_{(49)} = 73.27, p = .014$). Together, the three variables accounted for 38% of the variance in the relationship between individual incivility and well-being.

As reported in Table 2, Hypothesis 2 was not supported as incivility team climate was not a significant moderator of the experienced incivility–well-being relationship. However, competitive team norms was a significant moderator of the experienced incivility–well-being relationship ($t = 2.34, p < .05$), thus supporting Hypothesis 4. The cross-level interaction accounted for 17.8% of the variance in slopes beyond the effect of size and climate. Figure 1 illustrates that as hypothesized, there was a stronger negative relationship between experienced incivility and well-being for those who worked in teams with less competitive team norms (1 SD below the mean) compared to those who worked in teams with higher competitive team norms (1 SD above the mean).

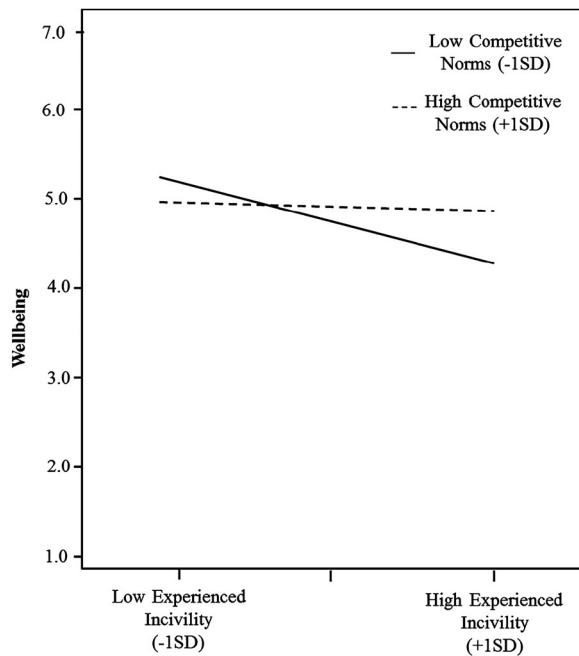


Figure 1. Relationship of experienced incivility with well-being: the moderating effect of competitive team norms.

Hypothesis 5 was also supported, with team size being a significant moderator of the incivility–well-being relationship ($t = 2.36$, $p < .05$). The cross-level interaction, experienced incivility $\times$ team size, accounted for 19.1% of the variance in slopes beyond the effect of team climate and norms. Figure 2 illustrates the expected relationship of experienced incivility with well-being for two levels of team size (± 1 SD), where there was a stronger negative relationship for respondents who worked in smaller teams.

At a reviewer's suggestion, we added aggregated experienced incivility to represent a measure of team incivility norms, which has been used in previous research (Griffin, 2010; Lim et al., 2008), to examine whether the results of this study operate similarly when the aggregated measure is included in the analysis. The analysis presented in Table 2 was repeated to incorporate aggregated experienced incivility. Aggregated experienced incivility did not have a direct or interactive effect on employee well-being, with or without team incivility climate included. In addition, the inclusion of the aggregated variable did not significantly change the results, and therefore is not reported in this paper.

Discussion

While previous studies have recognized the likely role that the work environment plays in facilitating and shaping employees' reactions to interpersonal mistreatment (Cortina & Magley, 2009; Duffy et al., 2006; Griffin, 2010; Paulin & Griffin, 2015), the influence of work teams on outcomes from individually experienced incivility has not previously been systematically investigated. Based on a model proposed by Wrzesniewski et al. (2003), we hypothesized that the within-team competitive norms, team climate for

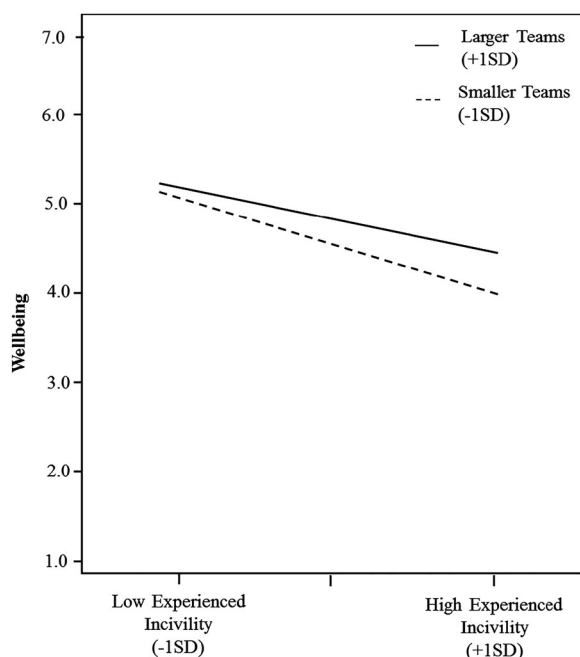


Figure 2. Relationship of experienced incivility with well-being: the moderating effect of team size.

incivility and size of a team are factors that guide sensemaking and social comparison for team members and therefore would influence the effect of experienced incivility on well-being. Results indicate that team members do not necessarily have to be direct targets to experience the negative effects of uncivil behaviour, but rather, the size and normative behaviour of their team influence how they respond to personal experiences of incivility. Overall, the findings of this study make several important contributions to both the incivility and work team literature.

We found that team incivility climate had a direct negative relationship with employee well-being, over and above the individual-level effect of incivility. Employees appear to have been affected not only by their direct personal experiences of incivility, but also by the team environment and climate that they were exposed to. The negative relationship between incivility climate and employee well-being, even after controlling for personal experiences of incivility, highlights workplace incivility as a team or organizational problem, rather than just a result of individual factors (Glomb & Hulin, 1997).

In contrast to Duffy et al. (2006) and Griffin (2010), we did not find a significant moderating effect of incivility team climate on the relationship between experienced incivility and employee well-being. This result may highlight some differences in the effect of team- and organizational-level incivility, as both Duffy et al. (2006) and Griffin (2010) found support for the singled-out hypothesis when examining the effect at the organizational level of analysis, whilst this study examined the effect at the team level. Our results may also be a result of differences in the outcome measures used across the studies, with Duffy et al. (2006) and Griffin (2010) focusing on two cognitive outcomes (job satisfaction and turnover intentions), whilst this study focused on an affective outcome (well-being). According to fairness theories, when employees perceive that they are being treated

unfairly, they are likely to cognitively alter their commitment to the organization, to reduce dissonance and restore feelings of justice (Karriker & Williams, 2007), therefore supporting a stronger singled-out effect on cognitive outcomes, such as intention to remain and job satisfaction, compared with affective well-being, which may be further impacted by the negative climate.

As predicted, competitive team norms had a negative effect on job-related affective well-being and also moderated the relationship between experienced incivility and well-being, with the negative effect stronger for those who worked in teams with less competitive norms. Conversely, the negative effect of experienced incivility on well-being was reduced when respondents worked in teams with higher competitive team norms, such that the relationship between incivility and well-being stayed constant irrespective of the amount of incivility. Guided by sensemaking theory (Ashmos & Nathan, 2002), targets of uncivil behaviour working in teams with higher competitive norms may be able to reframe workplace incivility, perhaps by interpreting it as a by-product of competition rather than an intentional demeaning behaviour, thereby reducing its overall impact on their well-being. Targets of uncivil behaviour working in teams with lower competitive norms may not be able to reframe such uncivil behaviour in the same way, thereby increasing the negative impact of high incivility on well-being.

The magnitude of the relationship between experienced incivility and affective well-being was also influenced by team size, in that the negative effect was stronger for those who worked in smaller teams. The results revealed that at low levels of incivility, small teams enjoy similar levels of well-being as large teams. However, at high levels of incivility, the effect of such behaviour is more detrimental to the well-being of employees working within smaller teams. In contrast, team size had no direct effect on well-being.

This significant moderating effect of team size supports previous research on team design, which suggests that the composition of a team can significantly affect the quality of team members' experiences at work (Ogungbamila, Ogungbamila, & Adetula, 2010). Aube et al. (2011) also found that larger teams reduced the strength of the relationship between counterproductive behaviours and the internal team functioning. Our result supports Social Comparison Theory, which posits that direct social comparisons are more easily generated in small teams where physical closeness and social interactions are high. Furthermore, increased opportunity for social comparison in small teams may result in targets of incivility feeling more singled-out and experiencing self-conscious emotions such as humiliation, embarrassment and shame (Greenberg et al., 2007).

Practical implications

The results of this study have some important implications for practitioners and managers. First, the direct effect of team incivility climate found in this study reinforces the significant costs to the individual and the employer of workplace incivility that have been examined in previous individual-level studies of workplace incivility (Cortina et al., 2001; Lim et al., 2008; Penney & Spector, 2005). However, because the impact of incivility extends beyond just those who directly experience such behaviour, the results suggest that the full cost of workplace incivility may not be fully appreciated. Ignoring such team climates is far from harmless, with Pearson and Porath (2009) estimating the

cost of workplace incivility to a business to be as much as \$14,000 a year per employee as a result of distraction from work and project delays. If workplace incivility is allowed to permeate the team environment, the costs to employers will continue to rise. Managers who are able to understand the social context of incivility may be more able to effectively assess and address those factors in the climate that encourage uncivil behaviours.

Our findings also reinforce the need to understand that the characteristics, shared mental models, and climates of teams influence the way individual team members appraise and react to experienced incivility (Roberson & Stevens, 2006). Managers may well need to consider the characteristics and context of their team when implementing any strategies or interventions aimed at addressing workplace incivility. These results bolster the importance of developing fair and respectful team environments, and addressing workplace incivility early (Bliese & Jex, 2002; Cortina et al., 2001).

The multilevel results of this study underscore the importance of a multipronged approach to preventing and reducing incivility, with interventions targeting both the team climate and specific, individual “episodes” of incivility. Collectively, our findings highlight the importance of diagnosing and addressing workplace incivility, particularly within smaller teams where the impact of experiencing such behaviour is especially harmful.

Limitations and future research directions

The results of this study should be evaluated in light of its limitations. Similar to most studies of workplace incivility, this study relied on cross-sectional data, limiting our ability to make any definitive inferences about causality. Despite this, diary studies and longitudinal research on interpersonal deviance provide strong support for employee well-being resulting from workplace incivility, rather than preceding it (Beattie & Griffin, 2014; Glomb, Munson, Hulin, Bergman, & Drasgow, 1999). Nonetheless, more longitudinal research is required to investigate the causal relationships and evolution of process between team incivility climate and employee outcomes.

In addition, the reliance on self-report measures raises concerns about the potential for common method bias (Podsakoff, MacKenzie, Lee, & Podsakoff, 2003). However, the application of multilevel analysis, with individual responses for the outcome and team-level variables being aggregated to the team level and checked for within-group agreement, helps to minimize the common method variance problem (Podsakoff et al., 2003). Although participants came from work teams from five organizations across a range of industries with differing organizational structures, all five organizations represented traditional white-collar professions. It would therefore be beneficial to conduct future research on the influence of uncivil team climates in blue-collar environments before generalizing the findings. Additionally, this study has not looked at team incivility climate within geographically dispersed or virtual workplaces. Given the increasing use of virtual and dispersed work teams, understanding the mechanism by which incivility climates affect virtual teams represents an important area for future research.

The significant direct effect of incivility climate and competitive norms, as well as the interaction effects of competitive climate and team size, should also be interpreted in light of the relatively small effect sizes found in this study. Whilst small effect sizes are common

in organizational research, the results suggest that a proportion of variance was left unexplained, supporting the need for further research in this area.

Finally, the results of this study reveal the importance of investigating team-based interventions aimed at addressing team climates of incivility. Despite the clearly defined problem, very little research has tested or produced convincing evidence supporting effective interventions (Leiter, Laschinger, Day, & Oore, 2011). Indeed, this study highlights the need for future research to investigate team-based interventions to improve civility within work teams and enhance employee well-being.

Conclusion

By taking a multilevel perspective, this study offered a unique opportunity to examine the effect of team incivility climate on employees' experiences of incivility at work, as well as providing empirical evidence on how individual and team-level factors interact to influence employee outcomes of workplace incivility. The results reveal a direct negative relationship between team incivility climate and job-related affective well-being, over and above the effect of individually experienced incivility, and indicate that the relationship between individuals' experiences of incivility and job-related affective well-being is moderated by team size and competitive team norms. The findings of this study have important implications for interventions aimed at reducing the negative effects of workplace incivility.

Disclosure statement

No potential conflict of interest was reported by the authors.

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